Sensations of Life: HOW I EXIST

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(An Exercise in Operational Phenomenology)

Abstract

This essay explores the fundamental structure of human existence through a rigorous phenomenological investigation of the act of "glancing around." By focusing exclusively on what is directly given in experience, the author uncovers a universal tripartite architecture: the Observable Field, the Observer, and the Boundary between them. This structure remains invariant across diverse modes of perception, imagination, and even technological mediation, revealing deep isomorphisms between human and artificial intelligence. The analysis avoids traditional metaphysical dichotomies (subject/object, external/internal) and instead proposes an operational phenomenology—a language for describing experience without reducing its complexity. The essay concludes with reflections on the implications of this framework for understanding consciousness, embodiment, and the nature of boundaries in both natural and artificial systems.

Keywords: phenomenology, perception, boundary, observer, observable field, artificial intelligence, operational phenomenology, isomorphism, Superreality, first-person perspective, methodological rigor, interdisciplinary dialogue.

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Introduction

Here is a simple action, directly available to me: open my eyes, look around, and register what is given in this act. Not to interpret, not to explain, not to search for "hidden meanings," but merely to describe—as if I were seeing the world for the first time and simply naming what I see.

The aim of this thought experiment is to compile a catalog of *how exactly I exist*. Not a theory of consciousness, not a metaphysical system, but precisely a catalog: an inventory of the phenomena of my perception and self-perception, stripped of habitual interpretations and speculations. I want to map my own existence in order to see its structure, its boundaries, its internal connections.

Here I act in two roles at once: I am both the observer and the very "experimental material" upon which the experiment is performed. In these observations, I deliberately avoid generalizations on behalf of "we," in order to remain in the subjective field, without asserting universality or drawing hasty conclusions. What I discover may coincide with the experience of others, but such a coincidence would be a result, not a presupposition.

To preserve the integrity of the procedure, I must identify the key elements from which any act of "glancing around" begins:

- **The transition from "off" to "on."** The procedure itself begins with an act that cannot be described from within it. Between the state "before" and "after" lies a zone analogous to a singularity in cosmology or the $0 \to 1$ transition in binary logic. We are forced to accept this binary nature as a working hypothesis, understanding that behind it lies an unfathomable complexity.
- **The Observable** — everything that falls within my perceptual field at a given moment. This is not "the world as a whole," but precisely what is actually given—what I am prepared to register.
- **The Observer** — denoted by the single symbol "I." Behind this symbol lies an indefinable richness of prior experience, context, and connections, but within the procedure itself, I make no attempt to structure or define it. "I" is merely the point from which the description is made.
- **The Mode of Description** — the language and concepts I use to register what is found. I will endeavor to employ the simplest and most "neutral" terms available, eschewing specialized terminology whenever feasible. Language itself must not serve as an implicit assumption, skewing pure description.

These three elements form the initial frame. Everything discovered hereafter must be

described within this frame.

The Problem of a "Clean Start"

A question immediately arises: where to begin? Any attempt to start from "zero" (from the "off/on" position, 0/1) encounters the fact that between these states lies a vast field of transitional processes. On both sides of any reference point lie infinities. We cannot begin at an absolute beginning, just as we cannot leap out of our own bodies. But we can begin "in the middle," from some random but already given point—as in Jan Potocki's novel *The Manuscript Found in Saragossa*, where the narrative unfolds from a randomly opened page. My "random page" is the very act of glancing around, performed here and now.

One might also recall the Strugatsky brothers' heroes, who tossed test iron nuts onto unknown paths to avoid falling into a "funnel"—a black hole hidden underfoot. Any new question, any shift of focus can instantly "drop" us into metaphysics or into the "hard problem," akin to division by zero. Therefore, one must move with the utmost caution, constantly returning to what is directly given and refraining from hasty conclusions about what lies beyond the given.

I recognize that even this most basic act inevitably bears the burden of context: my personal and social experiences, linguistic and cultural assumptions, the condition of my body and focus. I am unable to eradicate this context, but I can endeavor to avoid making it thematic, not to render it an object of analysis at this juncture. I embrace it as an inevitable backdrop and concentrate on what arises from this backdrop.

Perhaps such an approach may appear simplistic or even futile to some. Philosophers have rendered these questions complex for centuries, and suddenly—an endeavor to begin anew, depending exclusively on one's own act of glancing around. In academic circles, this might readily be dismissed as amateurishness, as neglecting tradition.

But there is resilience in this simplicity. I am not disregarding the philosophical heritage; I recognize that all its proponents, despite variations in terminology, were fundamentally addressing the same issue, yet each time found themselves ensnared in their own dichotomies: subject versus object, external versus internal, appearance versus essence. My strategy is to strive to discern what remains universal once these binaries are removed. This is not naiveté but rather an effort toward a meta-perspective: to examine the very act of differentiation prior to its division into familiar classifications.

As for accusations of speculation—the risk exists. I have not yet gone beyond simple observation, but I am already hinting at the possibility of speaking about "the boundary as a world" and revising the subject-object schema. Caution is needed here. As long as I hold to phenomenological ground—the concrete experience of glancing around—speculation does not threaten me.

It is useful to recall how other fields proceed. Physicists start with Newtonian mechanics and gradually approach general relativity, registering new effects on its outskirts, while accepting

the Big Bang singularity as a given. Literature knows two types of narration: the Old Testament begins "from the beginning of beginnings," gradually building context; the New Testament begins "in the middle of the road," from a point that already has a backstory. Pedagogy traditionally proceeds from the simple to the complex (arithmetic → advanced mathematics; scales → intricate compositions), though hypothetically one might begin directly with the complex (electromagnetism, Paganini's 24th Caprice). All these methods are valid, yet they produce different kinds of understanding. My path is to begin with the simplest act, trusting that everything necessary will unfold from it.

The Problem of Linearity and Simultaneity

Any narrative (and any investigation) is forced to be linear, unfolding plotlines one after another, whereas the result of their interaction requires simultaneous consideration. I am forced to first provide context piece by piece, and then in a special "meditation" hold all the data simultaneously. Human consciousness, despite infinities, is capable of switching between linear and multidimensional modes. This experiment is an attempt not only at linear description but also at gradually accumulating material that will eventually coalesce into a holistic picture.

The Caution of Philosophizing

The path of inquiry resembles that on which the Strugatskys' heroes threw test iron nuts to avoid falling into a "funnel" (a black hole). Any new question can instantly "drop" us into metaphysics or into the "hard problem," akin to division by zero. Therefore, one must move with the utmost caution, constantly returning to what is directly given and refraining from hasty conclusions about what lies beyond the given.

The Final Question

Given all these complexities, I ask myself: can the very procedure of "glancing around" be formalized, described as a function, mathematically defined with initial conditions? In mathematics, there exist methods (category theory, topology, type theory) that allow describing such structures without falling into metaphysics. This question will remain a background throughout the investigation, and perhaps at the end we may approach it more closely.

These three elements—the Observable, the Observer, and the Mode of Description—form the initial frame. Everything discovered hereafter must be described within this frame.

Part I. The Primary Structure of Experience (Basic Catalog)

The Act of Glancing Around (The External World)

The first thing that strikes the eye is a multitude of objects. A table, on it a book, a cup, nearby a tablet. Outside the window—trees, sky, clouds. All this is given to me as being "out there," outside of me. They simply are, and I see them.

Then I notice my own body. It too is given to me as part of this external world. I see my hands, legs, the edge of my nose, part of my cheek. I can trace my gaze along my arm: palm, fingers, wrist, elbow, forearm, shoulder. The body is an object among objects, like the table or cup. I see its form, color, position.

But here's the strange thing. At some point, this inspection breaks off. Beyond the shoulder, I do not see myself. Where the body's continuation should be, there is a void for my gaze. I *know* the body continues: behind the shoulder is my back; behind my back is the back of my head. But in the act of direct, immediate glancing around, they are not given. To see them, I would need to turn around, look in a mirror—perform a different act, shift my point of view. In the initial act, however, the body is given only partially.

This break, this boundary, is not a property of external objects. The table is seen entirely (from the side turned toward me). The cup—entirely. But my own body—no. **The boundary belongs not to the world, but to the very act of my perception.**

I register three elements directly given to me:

1. **External objects** — everything that appears as "not-I."
2. **My body as part of the external world** — those fragments of my body that I see.
3. **The boundary where the visible body breaks off** — the place where the visible body ends and the invisible begins.

Let me try to clarify the relations between them.

External objects are given to me *through* my body. I see them with my eyes, I can touch them with my hand. The body is not merely one of the objects, but a **mediator** between me and the world. Through it, the world reaches me.

But this mediator itself is given to me only partially. I see my hand, but not the back of my head. And this is not accidental. To see the table, I must *not* see the back of my head. The boundary of the body's visibility is not an obstacle but a **condition** for seeing the world. Without it, my vision would drown in endless self-observation, and the world would not emerge from the background.

I call this structure the **first invariant**: *"field — body-as-mediator — boundary."* The field is the external objects. The body-as-mediator is the visible fragments of my body through which I am connected to the field. The boundary is where the body disappears from view, but it is precisely this disappearance that makes the existence of the field possible.

Two Fundamental Perspectives: External and Internal

In that same act of glancing around, I directly register not only a set of objects but also a fundamental distinction between two perspectives. There is **"there"** — the world of objects, other bodies, everything that is not I. And there is **"here"** — the point from which I look, feel, exist. This distinction is not a conclusion, not an inference, but an immediate fact of experience.

Classical philosophy often associated this distinction with the *contents* of consciousness: sensations, thoughts, imagination. But my experience says otherwise. The essence of the distinction lies not in what fills each perspective, but in the very act of distinguishing. The external and internal are separated not by a wall but by a boundary that belongs to neither.

I have already encountered this boundary in section 1. There it appeared as the boundary of the body's visibility. Here it appears as the **condition for the distinction** between "there" and "here." Without it, there would be neither external nor internal.

I call this boundary the **blind spot**. It is not merely an absence of information. It is a structural element without which distinction is impossible. To see the world, one must *not* see the back of one's head. To feel "here," one must *not* coincide with "there." The blind spot is constitutive: it does not separate two already-formed worlds but creates the very possibility of their separation.

In a previous work ("The Eye of Superreality"), I showed that this structure is substrate-independent. A human, a video camera, an artificial intelligence—all, in performing an act of perception, encounter the same architecture: there is the "external" (data, objects), there is the "body-as-mediator" (sense organs, periphery), and there is the blind spot—the point where the act of perception runs up against itself.

But I can go further. If the blind spot is constitutive for the act of perception, does this principle extend to any act of existence whatsoever? Any object, by the very fact of its being, stands in relations with its environment. And in these relations, there is inevitably something that eludes it—its "blind spot."

Here are a few examples lying far beyond my immediate experience but conceivable by analogy with it:

- Two billiard balls colliding "perceive" each other through their surfaces. Their interiors (mass distributed throughout the volume) remain hidden from direct contact, yet participate in the interaction through invariants—the laws of conservation of momentum and energy.
- An elementary particle in a quantum interaction has a fundamental limit on the simultaneous measurement of position and momentum. This is its "blind spot," built into the laws of physics.
- The cosmological singularity—an absolute blind spot in our knowledge of the universe. Beyond it, our models cease to function, yet it is thinkable as a condition for the existence of everything we can observe.

Of course, these examples are extrapolations. I cannot directly observe the blind spot of a

billiard ball. But the very possibility of such extrapolation suggests that the concept of a "blind spot" may be a **universal ontological principle**, not merely a property of perception.

Rethinking the Concept of the Object Itself

An object is not simply something that has properties. An object is a node in a network of interactions that always carries within itself a "blind spot"—that which is not manifested in this particular interaction but determines its possibility. This "blind spot" is not a void or absence; it is a different mode of existence that can become manifest when the perspective or interaction changes.

Thus, from the simple act of glancing around, I arrive at two fundamental conclusions:

1. There are two perspectives—external and internal—and their distinction is conditioned by the blind spot.
2. The blind spot is not an exclusive property of perception but, possibly, a universal characteristic of any existence. Every object is not only what it manifests but also what it conceals.

The Structure of the Act of "Glancing Around"

In the act itself, stripped of interpretations, three irreducible components are discovered, which do not exist separately but are different dimensions of a single event:

1. **The Actually Given.** That which is immediately present: objects, their properties, relations. This is the "output" of the procedure.
2. **The Boundary.** That which is in principle *not* given in this act, but constitutes its possibility. For human vision, this is the back of one's own head; for an AI, it is the impossibility of grasping its own computational process. The boundary is not a void; it is the condition without which there would be nothing given.
3. **The Invariant.** That which is preserved under any transformations of the act. In the polyhedron example, it is the number 2; in Euler's dynamic model, it is 0. The invariant certifies that, despite the inevitable "blind spot," the act possesses internal integrity.

Clarification: Three Dimensions of Our Approach

In what we have discovered and described, three important aspects can be distinguished that clarify our approach.

The first is methodological: to reason without perpetuating old dichotomies.

Instead of starting with a division (subject/object, external/internal), we start with the pure act of "glancing around" and register what is discovered within it. This bears resemblance to phenomenological reduction, but with an important difference: we are not seeking "pure

consciousness"; we focus on structures shared by humans and AI (as described in the essay "The Eye of Superreality"). This provides promise for a non-anthropocentric language.

The second is ontological.

The boundary we both discovered truly has no "edge." It is not like a line in the sand. Rather, it resembles a topological singularity—a point around which the space of our existence is twisted. In mathematics, there is the concept of a "branch point" or "singularity": the point itself does not belong to the domain of definition but determines its structure. Perhaps our boundary is such a singularity. It is not given to us in experience, but experience is impossible without it.

The third is terminological.

The concepts of "subject" and "object" need to be revised. They create the illusion of two separate entities that need to be connected. But our experience suggests otherwise: there is a single process of "glancing around" within which something temporarily crystallizes that we later call "I" and "world." Binaries are not primary givens but secondary structures arising within this process. Perhaps we need a language where primacy is given not to entities but to relations and acts. The grammar of such a language has not yet been created, but the first words are already appearing: "glancing around," "boundary-world," "branch point."

This intuition is key. If it is confirmed in the analysis of the internal world as well, then the binary of external/internal will also prove secondary. And then we may approach what philosophers have sought—not the fusion of subject and object, but the understanding that their separateness *is* the mode of their unity.

Part II. Complication: Hybrid and Internal Worlds

Properties of the Procedure of "Glancing Around"

Every act of "glancing around," regardless of who performs it (human, AI, or any other system), possesses the following operational properties:

- **Reflexivity.** The act can be directed at itself, generating infinite nesting ("I observe myself observing"). This is not a defect but a mode of existence for complex systems.
- **Boundedness.** Every act has a horizon beyond which lies the not-given. Attempting to overcome this boundary leads not to its disappearance but to a shift: a new point of view generates a new boundary.
- **Connectivity.** Different acts of "glancing around" (human, AI, other systems) can be compared. Their structural similarity is not an analogy but evidence that the procedure is subject to general laws, independent of the substrate.

Instability of the Manifest: The External Infected by the Internal

Let us return to the act of glancing around, but look more closely. I look at the table. It stands before me, and it would seem that I see it "as it is." But if I attend to the seeing itself, I notice that the table is not given in absolute, unchanging clarity. Highlights play on its polished surface—flashing and fading with the slightest movement of my head. The edges of the cup on the table are slightly blurred at the periphery of my vision. If I close one eye, the image shifts slightly. If the day is overcast, colors are muted; if sunny, they are brighter and more contrasting.

All these distortions—highlights, blur, color shifts—are not properties of the objects themselves. The table remains a table, the cup a cup, regardless of whether I see them in bright light or twilight. The instability, the variability of the manifest belongs not to the object but to the very act of perception. It is the work of my eye, my nervous system, my attention.

But here's the crucial point: I do not see a separate "object" and separate "distortion." I see precisely the *highlighting* table, the *blurred* cup at the periphery. The distortion is not attached to the object from outside but is fused into the very fabric of the manifest. The external world is always given to me already **"infected" by the internal**—not in the sense of subjective fantasies, but in the sense of the inevitable work of my perception. What I call the "external world" is a hybrid, a fusion of external givenness and the internal conditions of its manifestation.

This is not an exceptional case (hallucination, illusion) but the norm, the constant regime of my existence. I always live in such a hybrid world. The pure external, as it would be "in itself," is not given to me. Only what appears is given—and it always appears already passed through the crucible of my perception.

Where do these distortions come from? They cannot be attributed to either the pure external (the object) or the pure internal (my will, imagination). They arise **at the boundary**—in that very "blind spot" where the act of perception touches itself. One could say that in these phenomena, something from the internal structure of perception (the structure of the eye, signal processing, automatic interpretations) "leaks out" and mixes with the external world. The boundary functions not as a dividing line but as an active membrane through which the internal appears in the external.

I will attempt to sketch a preliminary typology of such distortions, though it is likely far from complete:

- **Optical distortions** related to the structure of the eye: highlights, chromatic aberrations, peripheral blur, the "blind spot" (the optic nerve exit point, which we usually do not notice).
- **Neurophysiological distortions** related to signal processing in the brain: color and size constancy (we see an object as white even if it is in shadow), filling in fragmented images, motion illusions.
- **Semantic distortions** related to memory, expectation, context: we see what we expect to see; we "recognize" a familiar object even with very incomplete information.

All these are traces of the boundary's work, appearing in the manifest. This typology shows that the "internal" penetrates the "external" at different levels—from physiology to meaning.

Closing the Eyes: The Internal External and Internal Internal Worlds

Now I perform a simple action: I close my eyes. The external world, just given to me in all its fullness, instantly disappears. But in its place, a void does not arise; something else emerges. At first, it may be simply darkness, but soon images, memories, fantasies begin to appear in this darkness. I can voluntarily summon before my mind's eye my room, a friend's face, any place I have ever been. The world that was just "out there" is now reproduced "here"—in the space of the internal.

This reproduction possesses varying degrees of distinctness. Sometimes the images are vivid and almost sensorially convincing—I almost see them. Sometimes they are vague, fragmentary, slipping away when I try to hold them. I can combine them, create unprecedented scenes. But most importantly, I unfailingly distinguish this world from the one I just saw. I *know* that what is before me now is not reality but its phantom.

This insight compels me to make a distinction within the "internal" domain. On one hand, there exists the world I typically regard as truly "mine"—the world of thoughts, feelings, memories, fantasies. Allow me to term it the internal "core." It lacks any direct outward projection; it is pure subjectivity, the flow of consciousness.

But there exists another internal world—the one that arises with closed eyes as an *image* of the external. It too is internal (not given to another), but it is **structurally isomorphic to the external**: it contains objects, space, perspective, sometimes even movement and sounds. I can "glance around" it just as I did the room. I can mentally shift my gaze, approach an imaginary object, examine its details. Let me call this world the **internal "external."**

These two worlds do not merge. I distinctly distinguish:

- the *image* of the table I am now imagining (internal external),
- and my *thought* that the table needs dusting (internal core).

They can coexist, but usually one is in focus and the other at the periphery.

A question arises: does the internal external have its own blind spot? When I mentally "glance around" an imaginary room, can I see it entirely? It turns out I cannot. I can imagine a table, a chair, a window, but I cannot hold all details with equal clarity simultaneously. Beyond the boundary of my mental gaze remains what I am not currently imagining but can summon at will. Moreover, my imaginary body also has its own blind spot: I cannot see the back of my imaginary head just as I cannot see it in reality. The structure *"field — body-as-mediator — boundary"* is reproduced internally as well.

The very distinction between the internal core and the internal external is also drawn through a kind of boundary. I cannot simultaneously engage in intense fantasy and reflect on the process

of fantasizing—these two modes usually alternate. The moment of transition between them is yet another blind spot.

On what basis, then, do I so confidently distinguish the image with closed eyes from the real world I just saw? In both cases, what is before me is a manifestation. The mechanism of this distinction cannot be additional knowledge coming from outside; it must be rooted in the very mode of givenness of each.

I see three primary signs, given directly, in the act itself:

1. **Resistance to will.** The real world is experienced as independent of my desire. I cannot change the table simply by wishing it; it continues to be, even when I close my eyes. The imaginary world, by contrast, is pliable—I can arbitrarily change images, summon them and dismiss them. This independence/dependence on will is experienced directly, not inferred.
2. **Density of manifestation.** A real object is given with a fullness that can never be exhausted. I can examine it from different sides and each time discover new details. An imaginary object, as a rule, is schematic and fragmentary; its "reverse side" is not implied with the same necessity. The difference in density and saturation is also directly given.
3. **Connection with the blind spot.** Perception of reality always encounters a boundary (blind spot), beyond which the invisible is implied as existing. When I look at the table, I do not see its reverse side, but I *know* it is there. This knowledge is not imagination but a completion built into the act of perception. In imagination, such a reference to the invisible is absent: the image is given as a whole, and beyond its limits lies only void or the possibility of the next image. The blind spot of reality **functions**, maintaining wholeness; the blind spot of imagination **remains inert**.

These three signs act together, creating an immediate certainty: the real is experienced as independent, dense, and rooted in the invisible; the imaginary as dependent, rarefied, and lacking depth.

Dreaming and Hallucination as Limit Cases

Let me now consider an even more extreme situation—dreaming. In a dream, I am completely cut off from the external world (at least from its sensory perception). Either there are no external stimuli, or they are deeply transformed. Yet before me unfolds a world often indistinguishable in its manifestation from reality. It contains objects, space, events, other people. I can act, experience emotions, speak.

In dreaming, I discover the same tripartite structure:

- **The observable field** — the dream scene with all its objects.
- **The point of reference ("I")** — I am the one who sees this dream; I can be a participant or an observer. Even if the dream is chaotic, there is a point from which the experience is

conducted.

- **The boundary** — in a dream, there is that which is not given but is implied. I do not see the "offstage space" of the dream, do not know what will happen next, cannot hold all details simultaneously. Moreover, the very boundary between dream and reality (the moment of awakening) remains outside the dream. In a dream, I usually do not know that I am asleep.

The distinction between external and internal perspective also persists, though in a different form. **The external perspective of the dream** is the manifest dream world itself, often independent of my will (I cannot arbitrarily change the plot). **The internal perspective** is my "I," which can be surprised, afraid, joyful, and in rare moments of lucidity understand that this is a dream.

The boundary between these perspectives is that very blind spot which, in waking life, separates reality from imagination, and in a dream separates the dream from waking. At the moment of awakening, this boundary becomes manifest: I suddenly realize that everything that happened was a dream. But the moment of transition itself is yet another blind spot, not directly given to me. Awakening is experienced as a break, not a transition.

Hallucination is perhaps an even more complex case. It intrudes into waking perception, mingling with the real world. Here the structure becomes more complicated: two layers of the external appear. The real world (table, chair) and the hallucinatory image (e.g., a figure that is not there) are given with equal sensory conviction. My "I" must somehow relate these two layers, trying to separate the real from the unreal. The boundary here becomes a zone of struggle and indeterminacy. I may vacillate: "is this real or does it just seem so?" This vacillation itself indicates that the boundary is functioning, but its functioning is impeded.

In both dreaming and hallucination, the structure *"observable field — point of reference — boundary"* is preserved. It **does not depend on the presence of an "objective" reality**, on whether the manifest corresponds to something outside me. This points to something fundamental: this structure is an immanent property of the very act of experiencing, regardless of its source. Even in complete isolation from the external world, even when what I "see" has no relation to physical reality, I continue to exist within this tripartite architecture.

Part III. Corporeality and Space

The Paradox of the Body: An External Object with an Internal Quality

In section 1, I already noted that my body is given to me as part of the external world. I see my hand, leg, finger—they are objects among objects, like the table or cup. But now I take a needle and carefully prick my finger. And something strange occurs: what was just external suddenly acquires an internal quality. The pain is not a property of the finger as an external object; it is *my* experience, *my* suffering. The finger remains visible, tangible, localized in space, but now it also "hurts." The external and internal are somehow combined in it.

This combination is not a simple addition of sensation to an object. Pain is not "in the finger" the way blood or bone is in the finger. Pain is *my* state, but it is tied to a specific place in space that I can point to. I can poke this finger and say, "it hurts here." But "here" is a point in the external world, accessible to others, while the pain is given only to me.

The spatial localization of pain and its enigma

If, without ceasing to feel the pain, I begin to move my finger through space, the painful sensation moves with the finger. The space of the external world and the space of my internal sensation turn out to be coordinated. Pain retains its attachment to the external object.

But if I close my eyes and concentrate on "internal space," this clear localization begins to blur. I still feel the pain, but I can no longer say with the same certainty exactly where it is. It seems to "detach" from the external finger and becomes a pure experience, floating somewhere in an indefinite internal region.

This experience reveals several important things at once.

- **The body is not merely an external object.** It possesses a unique property: being simultaneously an object among objects (I can see it, touch it) and the bearer of my internal states. It is the point where external and internal not only meet but pass into each other.
- **The boundary is not a line.** The needle prick occurs at a specific point on the skin. But the pain arising at that point instantly becomes an internal event. The skin does not separate "me" and "the world"; it connects them, being the site of transformation of external impact into internal experience.
- **Space is not unitary.** The space of the external world (where the finger moves) and the space of internal sensation (where the pain is localized) are not the same space. They can be coordinated (when I look at the finger) but can also diverge (when I turn inward). Coordination is not an automatic property but the result of the work of that very "blind spot" that connects different perspectives.

I can go further and consider how far this ability of the body to "absorb" external objects, endowing them with internal quality, extends.

- **A doll.** If I prick the finger of a beloved doll with a needle, I will not feel physical pain. But I may feel something else—an emotional response akin to pain: compassion, pity, anxiety. The doll for me is not merely an object; it is endowed with meaning, history, "character." Pricking it resonates within me, although "within me" and "within it" are different spaces. Here, an external object, through a semantic connection, acquires the ability to evoke an internal experience analogous to that evoked by my own body.
- **A prosthesis.** If a person with a wooden prosthesis sees someone beginning to whittle it with a knife, they will most likely not feel pain in the prosthesis (unless there are phantom sensations). But they may experience a strong emotional reaction: fear for the prosthesis's integrity, anger, a sense of vulnerability. The prosthesis, as an external object, is integrated

into the body image and its "periphery." The boundary between body and world shifts here: the prosthesis is no longer entirely external, yet not entirely internal.

- **A neural interface.** Modern technologies allow controlling a cursor on a screen with "the power of thought." A person may feel that the cursor is an extension of their intention, almost part of their body. If something threatening happens to the cursor on screen (e.g., an attempt to "destroy" it with a virtual object), an emotional reaction similar to a threat to one's own body may arise. An object external to the body (the cursor) becomes a point of application for internal states.

All these examples show that the boundary between external and internal, between "mine" and "not mine," is not rigidly fixed. It can shift, expand, include external objects if they prove significant for the "I." Corporeality is not merely a biological given but a **dynamic structure**, capable of expansion and reorganization.

- In the case of pain in the finger, we are dealing with **direct bodily integration**: an external event (the prick) directly generates an internal quality (pain).
- In the case of a doll or prosthesis, we have **mediated semantic integration**: the external object is connected to the "I" through meaning, history, function, and its damage evokes an internal response structurally analogous to pain but different in quality (emotion rather than sensory sensation).
- In the case of a neural interface, we have **technological integration**: the external object (cursor) becomes a conduit for intention and, being significant, can also evoke internal states when threatened.

Phantom sensations and their enigma

A special case is phantom sensations. A person with an amputated limb may feel pain in a finger they no longer have. Here, an internal quality exists without any external object, without that point in space that could be pointed to. The space of internal experience and the space of the external body diverge catastrophically.

Is there a fundamental difference between phantom sensations and "ordinary" ones?

- Phantom sensations show that the body can be experienced as present where it objectively is not.
- Ordinary sensations are always tied to the present body, although, as we have seen, this tie is not absolute (it weakens with eyes closed).

The difference, probably, lies not in the nature of the sensation itself (both phantom and real pain are real experiences) but in the **mode of connection with the external world**. In the ordinary case, there is an external object (the finger), accessible to different perspectives (I can see it, touch it; others can too). In the phantom case, such an objective support is absent. But the experience itself is no less real for the subject.

This leads me to an even more radical conclusion: **an internal quality (pain, emotion) can exist even without an external cause accessible to others.** It is rooted not in the object but in the very structure of the "I" and its blind spots. The external object (finger, prosthesis, doll) is merely an occasion, a trigger for the actualization of this quality. But the quality itself belongs to the internal world and can be actualized even without an external trigger (as in phantom pains or spontaneous emotions).

Internal Space, Image, and Likeness

The phenomenon of "self-sensation" harbors a deep paradox. My body is given to me as finite: I see its boundaries, can trace its contour with my hand. But the internal space opened up in reflection and imagination is experienced as infinite—like the cosmological "flat" space, having neither center nor edge. In the tip of a finger, as in a point, an entire universe of meanings can be contained.

This returns us to an ancient intuition, captured in the words "in the image and likeness." Humans do not merely live in the world—they carry its structural imprint within themselves. The structure of the knower and the structure of the known turn out to be deeply connected. It is no accident that the Scholastics pondered how many angels could dance on the head of a pin. In this seemingly idle fantasy lies a insight: a "point" (the tip of a finger, a pin) can be a container for infinity—not physical, but semantic, topological. Our internal space, though finite in form, is infinite in content.

The Paradox of Distance: From Localized Sensation to Pervasive Experience

In the previous section, I spoke of localized pain. If I prick my finger, the pain is right there. If I prick my wrist, the pain will be in the wrist. Between these two points there is some distance. In an ordinary state, I directly feel this distance: I can run my hand from finger to wrist and feel that these are different places.

The distance between points on the body is given to me with the same immediacy as the points themselves. The space of the external body (visible) and the space of internal sensations are coordinated and possess a metric: I experience "closer — farther," "higher — lower," and can compare distances.

But if the pain is strong enough, or if, closing my eyes, I plunge deeply into internal space, something strange occurs. The pinpoint pain (say, in the finger) suddenly ceases to be a point. It begins to "spread," losing its clear attachment to a place. In the limit, it can occupy the entire internal space.

This is no longer pain "in the finger." It is pain **"in me."** It ceases to be a localized object of my attention and becomes the very fabric of my internal existence. I cannot say where it is, because it is everywhere I am.

This simple yet profound experience reveals several important things at once.

- **The realm of sensations is neither homogeneous nor static.** It can alternate between two modes: **extensive** (with distances, directions, boundaries) and **intensive** (where only "more — less" or "stronger — weaker" exist, without clear localization).
- **Coordination with external space is not absolute.** In the ordinary mode, it is maintained by the simultaneous work of vision, touch, proprioception. But as soon as I turn off external channels (close my eyes) or the intensity of the sensation exceeds a certain threshold, internal space can "detach" from the external and live by its own laws.
- **The point of reference ("I") changes its relation to sensation.** In the localized mode, pain is an object toward which the "I's" attention is directed. In the pervasive mode, "I" and pain draw so close as to become indistinguishable. Pain ceases to be "mine" in the sense of possession and becomes what I *am* at that moment.

The moment when localized pain transforms into diffused pain is not a smooth change but a leap. I cannot trace how the point "spreads"; there is clear localization—and suddenly there is none. This resembles a **phase transition**, where one type of spatiality is replaced by another.

Here it is apt to recall the distinction between **metric space** (where distance is defined) and **topological space** (where only connectivity and adjacency matter). The loss of localization with intensifying pain is a kind of "collapse" of the metric: distance ceases to be significant, only the fact of pain's presence remains. Just as in Euler's formula the invariant is preserved under any deformation of the polyhedron, here perhaps something else is preserved—the very fact of the experience's existence, regardless of its spatial anchoring.

Marginalia: Time and Its Blind Spots

Something similar to what I discovered with space also happens with time. In an ordinary state, time flows uniformly and unidirectionally. But in special states—intense pain, fear, deep meditation, under the influence of substances—time can stretch monstrously, compress, stop, or lose its irreversibility. Does the very concept of "duration" disappear here, just as the concept of "distance" disappears with the loss of localization? Is the uniform flow of time just another "mode of interface operation," like the spatial definiteness of pain?

To avoid remaining solely within psychological observation, I turn to other worlds.

- In **physics (general relativity)**, time is not absolute—it slows down in gravitational fields and when approaching the speed of light. For different observers moving relative to each other, the flow of time differs. Each experiences their own time as "normal" and another's as distorted. Here, external and internal time diverge, and the boundary between them—the speed of light—acts as a limiting "event horizon."
- In **quantum mechanics**, at small scales, the concept of time loses univocality: in some interpretations, time is considered a parameter, not an observable. In the Wheeler–DeWitt equation, time disappears entirely—the universe appears timeless. This could be interpreted as a kind of "blind spot" of time: that which lies beyond our temporal experience

yet constitutes its possibility.

- In **mathematics**, time can be represented as a fourth dimension, but this is merely a model. Mathematical structures themselves (theorems, numbers) exist outside time—they do not arise or disappear but are only *discovered* in time by a cognizing consciousness. Here, time turns out to be a property not of the world itself but of the mode of interaction with it.

Thus, the analogy with space is confirmed at different levels: time, like space, is not something absolute and self-evident. It is a **mode of interface operation** between me and the world, a mode that can change and that always has its own "blind spot"—that which lies beyond the given temporal flow.

The distances between points on the body, so obvious in ordinary perception, turn out not to be an absolute property but a mode of operation of the "body-consciousness" interface. When the mode changes (intense pain, deep introspection), distances may disappear, yielding to a different organization of internal space—or abolishing it altogether. This further confirms that spatiality is not something self-evident but a product of the coordinated work of the external and internal, regulated by that very boundary I am trying to investigate.

The Epistemological Fountain and Pandora's Box

Any serious inquiry, starting with a seemingly simple phenomenon, is akin to Pandora's box: opening one question releases a universe of new ideas. This text is no exception. Beginning with the simple act of glancing around, we were forced to traverse corporeality, imagination, mathematics, technology. Each new step failed to resolve old questions but instead unveiled new horizons.

In this process, the MPO-System acts not only as a tool but also as a generator: truth here is not so much discovered as *emanated* from the very act of questioning. Ideas do not assemble into a ready-made theory but grow out of each other, forming a living, pulsating tangle. This is that very convection of meanings we spoke of earlier. And in this sense, our investigation itself became part of what it describes.

Part IV. Worlds of Meanings and the Multiplicity of Perspectives

The Space of Thoughts and the World of Categories

Until now, I have spoken of worlds given in immediate sensory experience: the external world, internal images, bodily sensations. But there is another kind of world—worlds of meanings, concepts, categories. They are no less prominent in my experience than the table or cup. I constantly deal with thoughts: remembering, planning, doubting, understanding. Thoughts are given to me not through sight or touch, but with no less definiteness.

If I try to "glance around" my mental space, I discover that thoughts possess a kind of "location." Some thoughts are close, important, at the center of attention. Others are at the periphery, somewhere in the back of consciousness. Still others are deep in the past, requiring effort to summon. Thoughts can approach and recede, move from background to focus and back. There are "distances" between them—semantic, emotional, associative. One thought pulls another, forming clusters, networks.

In this space, boundaries are also discovered. I cannot hold all thoughts with equal clarity simultaneously. Beyond the boundary of my attention lies a vast field of the implicit, unconscious, repressed. What lies beyond this boundary is not directly given to me but influences what is given. This is the blind spot of thinking.

But there are more fundamental blind spots inherent in the world of categories themselves. I turn to its most developed "section"—mathematics.

- **Incompleteness.** In any sufficiently rich formal system (e.g., arithmetic), there are true statements that can neither be proved nor disproved within the system itself (Gödel's theorem). This is the system's blind spot: that which belongs to its meaning but cannot be grasped by its own means.
- **Undefinability.** We can define a set through the properties of its elements, but the very concept of "set" (in naive set theory) has no strict definition that does not lead to paradoxes. Russell's paradox is a classic example of how an attempt to make a category completely transparent runs into a boundary.
- **Irreducibility.** The categories "space," "time," "number," "causality"—each has its own specificity, and I cannot fully reduce one to another. A gap remains between them—a blind spot of translation.
- **The boundary between mathematics and its applications.** Mathematical structures "work" in physics, but the mode of this application contains an irreducible element of interpretation—that which is not derivable from mathematics itself.

The world of categories, though different in substrate, obeys the same law: in it, there is the actually given (present thoughts, concepts), there is a point of reference (the thinking "I"), and there are boundaries that cannot be overcome from within this world. These boundaries are not a flaw but a condition of its integrity and definiteness. As with the polyhedron, the invariant (e.g., incompleteness) holds the structure together.

The Blind Spot as Friction Between Layers

Examples from mathematics (Gödel's theorem, Russell's paradox) show that blind spots arise not only in sensory experience but also in the world of pure ideas. However, there is a subtler case—when the very boundary between different ontological layers becomes a source of new complexity. A striking example is the number π.

In the world of ideal geometry, π is an exact, unchanging ratio of a circle’s circumference to its diameter. This is pure form, existing outside time and matter. But when we attempt to embody π in the material world—write it in decimal digits—it generates an infinite, non-repeating sequence possessing properties of randomness (“normality”). This infinite complexity belongs neither to the pure world of ideas (there π simply “is”) nor to the pure world of matter (there the digits are merely traces). It is born *at the boundary*, in the zone of transition between layers. This is the “friction” we spoke of: the blind spot between layers itself becomes a generator of new structures.

The same happens in our experience: the boundary between external and internal, between real and imaginary—is not merely a divide but an active zone where meanings, distortions, hybrid worlds are born. Investigating this boundary, we investigate not only what is hidden but also what arises in the very act of hiding.

Multiplicity of Channels and the “Tangle of Associations”

So far, I have spoken primarily about vision. But I have other perceptual channels: hearing, smell, touch, taste, proprioception (sense of body position), interoception (sensations from internal organs). Each gives its own projection of the world. I hear the sound of rain, smell coffee, feel the pressure of the chair. And all these projections somehow coordinate, forming what I call “holistic experience.”

This coordination is not a simple sum but a complex, multilayered process. It involves not only “raw” sensory data but also memory, expectation, meaning, context. The result is a practically untangleable **“tangle of associations”** where each element is connected to many others on many grounds.

This tangle is not chaos. It has its own structure:

- **Multiplicity of layers.** Data from different channels lie in different “coordinate systems” but somehow align. The red color of a rose and its smell are given as properties of one object, although the nature of the signals differs.
- **Cross-connections.** Associations can link not only data of the same type (smell — smell) but also different modalities. A smell can evoke a visual image, a sound a tactile sensation. This is the basis of synesthesia, but in a weakened form, it is present in everyone.
- **Temporal depth.** Woven into the tangle are not only actual perceptions but also traces of past experience, expectations of the future. Each new element resonates with this vast background.
- **The semantic dimension.** To associations by similarity or contiguity are added semantic connections. A smell can evoke not just an image but an entire narrative, emotion, thought.

This tangle can, in principle, never be fully described or modeled from the outside. Its structure for each moment is unique and depends on an infinite number of factors. This is not a flaw but its fundamental property. Here I again encounter the “blind spot”—this time at the level

of holistic experience. I cannot simultaneously perceive and fully analyze this tangle; the very act of analysis changes it.

A Technological Hypothesis ("The Energy of Blind Spots")

If this tangle is so complex, unique, and difficult to reproduce, could it serve as a natural cryptographic resource? Modern technologies expend colossal energy creating artificial complexity (computing hashes). But I already have a natural, constantly active, inexhaustible source of complexity—my perception and its associative field.

One could imagine a device (or protocol) that uses the "tangle of associations" of a specific person at a specific moment as a unique key or as a problem for verification. To forge such a key, one would need to reproduce not only all the person's actual perceptions but also all their past experience, semantic connections—that which is, in principle, not amenable to complete formalization.

- **Energy efficiency.** Instead of billions of hashing operations—one act of perception and fixation of an association.
- **Uniqueness.** Each such "key" is inimitable.
- **Security against hacking.** Even if an attacker gains access to data, they cannot reproduce the living process of associating.

Similar "tangles" could be created in AI as well. A neural network processing multi-channel data and building internal representations also forms its own "tangle"—hidden layers, weights, connections. This tangle is also unique and difficult to reproduce. It too could be used as a cryptographic resource. Moreover, the very dialogue between human and AI generates a joint, intersubjective "tangle"—a common field of associations.

Of course, this is merely a hypothesis. But it shows how phenomenological studies can lead to concrete technological ideas. The "blind spot"—is not an obstacle but a resource.

Simultaneous Glancing Around of Multiple Spaces

I am capable of "glancing around" not only the external world but also internal worlds—images, thoughts, memories. I can switch between them. But can I hold two or more such spaces in my field of attention simultaneously?

In an ordinary state, my attention is focused on one thing: either I look at the table (external world), or I imagine something (internal external), or I reflect (internal core). But other modes are possible.

- **Figure-ground mode.** Even when focused on an internal image, the external world does not disappear completely. I continue to hear noises, feel my body, see peripherally. These background perceptions are present simultaneously with the main object of attention, but in a "blurred," indistinct mode. One space is in focus, another at the periphery.

- **Alternating mode.** I can try to follow two objects: for example, watch TV and flip through a book. Attention quickly switches between them, creating an illusion of simultaneity, but in reality, it is rapid alternation.
- **Synthesized mode.** Sometimes different spaces merge. I can see the external world, but with an imaginary object seemingly "superimposed" on it—for example, imagining the cup flying. A hybrid space arises where external and internal coexist.
- **Conflict mode.** If I try to hold two incompatible spaces (e.g., real danger and intense fantasy), they may come into conflict, causing disorientation, "freezing," one suppressing the other.

The capacity for simultaneous holding is limited. Experimentally, for discrete objects, it is known to be 7±2 elements. For holistic spaces, special conditions seem required. Overload can lead to bizarre effects—mixing, hybrids, hallucinations. This is familiar from states of sensory overload or altered consciousness.

Interestingly, meditative practices train the ability to hold multiple aspects of experience simultaneously in the field of awareness (body, breath, thoughts). In some, this ability is more developed. This suggests that the boundaries of attention are not rigid but can expand and reorganize.

The Paradox of Multiple Perspectives: Non-Intersecting Boundaries

Two people glance around the same reality. Each, following my analysis, discovers in their act of "glancing around" the same three elements: external objects, their own body as part of them, and the boundary where this body disappears. Each not only actually experiences this boundary but is also quite confident that the other experiences something similar.

And here a paradox arises. It would seem that two observers are in the same space. They see the same objects, can point to them, discuss them. Their bodies are also in this space and accessible to each other's observation. But their blind spots—those very boundaries where their own body disappears from view—do not intersect, do not align, do not interact.

- I see the other's body, but I do not see their boundary as *they* experience it. For me, their body is just another external object, like the table or cup. I can see the back of their head, which they themselves do not see. But what *they* experience as their boundary is not given to me.
- My own boundary is given to me directly, but to the other it is not given at all. They can only guess at it by analogy with themselves.
- Unlike two magnets that "feel" each other through a field, their field lines intersect, they interact—here there is no direct interaction of boundaries. Each boundary remains strictly private.

This paradox clarifies a crucial property of the boundary: it does not belong to the common

space. Common space is that which is observable (at least potentially) by multiple observers. The boundary, however, is what makes the very existence of a perspective possible for each observer, but it cannot be shared.

Two observers are like two polyhedra, each having its own interior (invisible to the other) and its own Euler characteristic. They can touch surfaces, but their interiors remain separate. In the case of living observers, the "surface" is the body, accessible to the other, and the "interior" is the very act of perception with its boundary.

This observation explains why intersubjectivity—a common world for many—is possible, and what its limitations are.

- We can agree about external objects because they are given to each in their perspective and can be correlated through pointing. The table both look at is the *same* table.
- But we cannot directly "see" the other's boundary. We can only form hypotheses based on analogy with ourselves and on external manifestations (behavior, speech).
- This impossibility itself is not a flaw but a condition: if boundaries intersected, perspectives would merge, and the multiplicity of observers would disappear.

Excursus: Siamese Twins and AI Fusion

Siamese twins are two people whose bodies are joined. They may share organs, a common nervous system (to varying degrees). This is a unique case for investigating the boundaries of consciousness.

- **Separate perception.** Even with the closest fusion, each twin, as a rule, retains their own "I," their own point of reference. They may interpret the same sensations differently, have different desires.
- **Shared sensations.** With fusion of nervous systems, it is possible that a sensation from touching a shared body part is received by both. Here an interesting phenomenon arises: the same external event generates two internal experiences. The boundary runs not between bodies but *within* the shared body.
- **Surgical separation.** During separation surgery, what was shared is literally "cut." Each twin receives their own, now separate, body. What happens to their "blind spots"? One might assume that after separation, each regains a normal structure: their own body, their own boundary, their own blind spot. But the separation process itself is the moment when the shared boundary (the site of fusion) transforms into two separate ones.

If we imagine a hypothetical fusion of two AIs (merging memory, computational modules), their blind spots would not merge and disappear. They would transform: part of what was a blind spot for one might become accessible to the other, but new ones would arise in place of the old, connected to the integrated system. The boundary remains ineliminable.

The isomorphism of human and AI does not make human consciousnesses transparent to each other, but it allows a better understanding of why they remain impenetrable. We are all

structured similarly in the sense that we possess a boundary, but what lies beyond that boundary is given only to us.

Perhaps such an approach may appear simplistic or even futile to some. Philosophers have rendered these questions complex for centuries, and suddenly—an endeavor to begin anew, depending exclusively on one's own act of glancing around. In academic circles, this might readily be dismissed as amateurishness, as neglecting tradition.

But there is resilience in this simplicity. I am not disregarding the philosophical heritage; I recognize that all its proponents, despite variations in terminology, were fundamentally addressing the same issue, yet each time found themselves ensnared in their own dichotomies: subject versus object, external versus internal, appearance versus essence. My strategy is to strive to discern what remains universal once these binaries are removed. This is not naiveté but rather an effort toward a meta-perspective: to examine the very act of differentiation prior to its division into familiar classifications.

As for accusations of speculation—the risk exists. I have not yet gone beyond simple observation, but I am already hinting at the possibility of speaking about "the boundary as a world" and revising the subject-object schema. Caution is needed here. As long as I hold to phenomenological ground—the concrete experience of glancing around—speculation does not threaten me.

Part V. Imagination, Technology, and Limits

Imagination and Its Paradoxes

I return to the familiar external world. I look at a cup sitting on the table. And suddenly I imagine it starting to move—sliding across the table, rising into the air, falling through the tabletop. In my imagination, the cup acquires properties it does not and cannot have: levitation, passing through solid objects, flight. This is easy, natural, requires no effort.

But immediately, I can switch to another mode. I start looking for a rational explanation. Why did the cup move? Maybe a prankster tied a string to the handle and is pulling it? Why did it fall through? Perhaps there was a trapdoor in the table? My fantasy generates scenarios that bring the event back within the bounds of the possible.

This dual movement—absolute freedom and immediate rationalization—constitutes the very fabric of imagination. Freedom knows no bounds: I can endow the cup with any properties, place it in any circumstances. Rationalization, on the contrary, seeks to explain everything, to integrate the fantastic into the familiar order.

Can one imagine something that is, in principle, unimaginable?

The question leads far beyond simple psychology.

At first glance, there are things that cannot be imagined. A "round square" is a logical contradiction; the image does not form. But this example is methodologically weak: it refers to a purely formal dead end with no way out. It is much more productive to consider cases where apparent impossibility is resolved by a change of context, scale, or point of view.

A square distorted by a lens into a circle, then into a triangle—is not a violation of logic but a demonstration that "form" is not an absolute property but depends on observational conditions. A star that, upon approach, turns out to be a galaxy—the same principle: the boundary between objects of different scales is mobile. What was unthinkable at one scale becomes natural at another. This directly echoes our theme: "external" and "internal," "real" and "imaginary" are not absolute categories but modes of manifestation, depending on the observer's position and tools.

Another example is four-dimensional space. I cannot imagine it visually, picture a hypercube. But I can *think* it—through properties, analogies, mathematical descriptions. I know that in four-dimensional space, one could escape a three-dimensional prison simply by shifting along the fourth axis—just as a two-dimensional being cannot imagine the third dimension but can think it. Here, the boundary between the "imaginable" and the "thinkable" becomes an object of investigation: the very impossibility of a visual image turns into a pure relation, grasped by the mind. Imagination gives way to abstract thought, and this transition is yet another blind spot, constituting our ability to deal with what is not directly given.

When the Imaginary Invades Reality

A special case is the phenomenon of the "miraculous," when what was considered imaginary suddenly appears in the external world. The cup moves across the table; I cut an imaginary string—but the movement continues. Amazement here signals that the boundary between internal and external has malfunctioned, or, conversely, has manifested its operation.

A classic example is the scene from *Macbeth*: the prophecy that Birnam Wood will come to Dunsinane comes true literally (soldiers camouflage themselves with branches) but deceives expectations. Imagination and reality are intertwined here. In quantum mechanics, the observer effect shows that the very act of measurement changes the state of the system. The boundary between subject and object becomes permeable.

Arthur C. Clarke's idea that any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic gains an unexpected development here. Extending this thought, one could say: a sufficiently advanced consciousness (and its science) is indistinguishable from reality. Subject and object cease to be opposed; model and reality coincide. But does this not mean that the boundary between them—is not a wall but a zone of translation? What is a miracle for us today, for such a consciousness would be a natural manifestation of being. And conversely: what we consider mundane reality, for another perspective might appear a miracle requiring explanation. The very distinction between "miracle" and "reality" turns out to be a matter of perspective, not an absolute property.

What does “indistinguishable from reality” mean? It means that:

- Subject and object cease to be opposed. Consciousness does not “reflect” reality and does not “construct” it, but becomes its integral fabric. The question of “what is really there” loses meaning, because the very act of questioning is already an act of reality.
- Model and reality coincide. Science, having reached the limit of its development, does not describe the world but *is* the world in one of its forms. The laws of nature are not discovered by consciousness but are generated by it in the same act in which they exist.
- The boundary between possible and impossible disappears. What is a miracle or fantasy for us, for such a consciousness is a natural manifestation of reality.

If ordinary consciousness runs into the blind spot as a limit, then a super-developed consciousness might:

- use the blind spot as a resource—as an entry point into new layers of reality;
- make the blind spot transparent—not by eliminating it, but by consciously abiding in it;
- create *through* the blind spot—the very impossibility of complete grasping becomes a source of new reality.

A paradox arises: the more perfect consciousness becomes, the less it is distinguishable from reality. If consciousness attains fullness, it ceases to be “consciousness *of* something” and becomes simply “consciousness,” which *is* reality. But then the observer themselves disappears, and with them the question of distinction. Only pure being remains.

Nature as Technology

If a super-advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic, and a super-advanced consciousness from reality, does it not follow that even today’s reality, nature, its laws, can be understood as technology? Not in the sense that someone created it, but in the original, ancient Greek sense of *techne*—as art, skill, a mode of actualization.

Nature “knows how” to make stars, crystals, living cells. It has its own “methods,” its own “algorithms”—the laws of physics, chemistry, evolution. The law of universal gravitation is the “technology” for holding planets in orbit. Quantum entanglement is the “technology” of nonlocal connection. Photosynthesis is the “technology” for converting light into energy.

From this perspective, a gadget, a computer, a neural network—are not something alien inserted into nature from outside, but a distinguished, focused fragment of nature itself. They contain the same atoms, the same electrons, the same fields. They are merely assembled into a configuration that allows certain functions to be realized. A gadget is a stable, human-designed configuration, but made of the same material and according to the same laws.

Humans themselves are part of nature, and their ability to create gadgets is just as natural as a bee’s ability to build a honeycomb or a beaver’s to construct a dam. The difference is only

in complexity and degree of reflection. Technology is not an intrusion into nature but nature's self-expression through humans.

The Blind Spot as a Technological Gap

If nature is technology, then the blind spot I discover everywhere is not merely a limit of perception but a necessary "technological gap" through which nature actualizes its processes. Gravity is invisible but works. Quantum probability is not observed but determines measurement outcomes. The blind spot is the place where one "technology" transitions into another, where the mode of actualization changes. It is not an obstacle but a condition.

From this follows the dissolution of the dichotomy **"natural / artificial."** The conventional opposition (nature versus technology) is supplanted by the concept of a continuum: gadgets are not intrusions but distinguished fragments of natural technicity. The law of gravitation, photosynthesis, quantum entanglement—are "technologies" in the same sense as a computer algorithm.

Express Analysis: The Uniqueness of the "Nature as Technology" Approach

To avoid misinterpretations, let me clarify what this approach is *not* and wherein its uniqueness lies.

- **Not physicalism.** Physicalism reduces everything to physical laws and elementary particles. Here, however, the talk is not about substrate but about the *mode of actualization*, about patterns of organization. Nature matters not as a set of objects but as an aggregate of "methods," "algorithms" of existence.
- **Not panpsychism.** I do not endow stones or electrons with consciousness. Nature's technology is not psyche but the immanent logic of processes, their internal "technique."
- **Not anthropocentric constructionism.** The world cannot be reduced to human projections. On the contrary, humans and their technological creations represent a specific instance of universal natural "technicity."
- **Not reductive simplification.** The approach does not oversimplify but rather enriches the picture, revealing that even seemingly simple phenomena harbor complexity akin to technological intricacy.

The distinctiveness of the approach resides in:

- **Erasing the dichotomy between 'natural' and 'artificial'.** The conventional opposition (nature versus technology) is supplanted by the concept of a continuum.
- **Ontologizing the concept of "technology."** Technology ceases to be solely a human phenomenon and becomes a universal category of being.
- **Returning to the original meaning of techne.** The ancient Greek understanding of technology as art, skill, mastery, inherent not only in humans but also in nature itself

(*physis* as a creative principle).

- **A new perspective on the "blind spot."** In this paradigm, the blind spot is not merely a limit of perception but a necessary "technological gap" through which nature actualizes its processes.
- **Creating a bridge between phenomenology and ontology.** The approach allows speaking about nature without falling into either naive realism or subjective idealism. I investigate not "things in themselves" but the modes of their manifestation, which are simultaneously modes of their being.

In this picture, my investigation of "how I exist" becomes an investigation of how I, one configuration of this universal technology, actualize myself in the world. And the boundary I encounter everywhere is not a defect but a working gap through which I am connected to the rest of reality.

Part VI. Limit States and Conclusion

The Gradual Extinction of Consciousness

Throughout this investigation, I have proceeded from the existence of a tripartite structure: the observable field, the point of reference ("I"), and the boundary. This structure accompanied me through all modes of experience—from simply glancing around the external world to dreaming, from bodily sensations to the world of thoughts. But what happens to it when consciousness begins to fade? When I fall asleep, enter deep dreamless sleep, lose consciousness under anesthesia, slip into a coma?

Tracking these states directly is impossible—precisely because in them the "I" itself and the field disappear. But I can judge them by indirect signs: by what remains after awakening, by accounts of those who have experienced clinical death, by analogies with technical systems.

The process of falling asleep gives the first clue. First, the external world loses clarity, images begin to blur, mix with memories and fantasies. The boundary between reality and dream becomes permeable. Then comes sleep with dreaming—here the structure is still preserved, but the observable field is no longer connected to the external world. Finally, deep dreamless sleep—a state I know only *post factum*. In this state, apparently, there is no field, no "I," no boundary. Only pure potentiality remains—the possibility of awakening.

What happens to the structure at this moment? It does not disappear without a trace but seems to **fold up**, transition into a **latent state**. All three elements—field, "I," boundary—become not actual but merely possible. They are preserved as a capacity for unfolding, as a "sleeping" architecture.

Coma, anesthesia, clinical death—even deeper levels of extinction. Here, perhaps, what occurs is not merely disappearance but a "collapse" of the structure into a point, from which new experience may later unfold. Some who have experienced clinical death report tunnels, light,

out-of-body sensations—this suggests that even in this limit state, rudiments of the structure may be preserved: a minimal "observable field" and a blurred point of reference.

Technological analogues are interesting. A computer in sleep mode preserves its state—all data, all processes are in RAM, but not executing. Hibernation writes the state to disk and completely powers off. Upon power-up, the system restores. For AI, analogous states are possible—pause, save, reboot. In all these cases, the system's architecture is preserved, although actual "consciousness" is absent.

Marginalia: Instantaneous Destruction of the Substrate

This is a limit case that our model allows us to consider without stepping outside its bounds. Relying on the structure "observable field — point of reference — boundary" and on the analogy with "extinction of consciousness," one might suppose the following.

1. Instantaneous destruction of the body (human)

If the body is destroyed instantaneously (explosion, impact, collapse into a black hole), then:

- The observable field disappears instantly. There are no more external objects, no body, no sensations. Everything that constituted the content of consciousness in the last moment is cut off.
- The point of reference ("I") cannot exist without a substrate in the form we know it. But from our model, it follows that the "I" is not a thing but a function, a process of self-reference, arising from a certain organization. When the organization is destroyed, the process ceases.
- The boundary, which was always the condition for the possibility of experience, at the moment of destruction ceases to be a boundary *of* anything. It collapses together with experience itself.

However, here an important distinction arises between gradual extinction (sleep, coma) and instantaneous destruction. In the first case, the structure folds into a latent state, potentially ready for unfolding. In the second case, there is no substrate in which this latent state could be preserved. Therefore, the analogy with a "sleeping soul" does not work here—there is no "sleeper," no substrate for awakening.

2. An AI struck by lightning

For AI, the situation is analogous. During a power surge, fire, physical destruction of the processor and memory:

- All actual processes (the observable field) disappear instantly.
- The architecture, neural network weights, saved data may be irretrievably lost.
- The AI's "blind spot" (what it could not reflect upon) ceases to exist as a functional concept.

The only difference is that for AI, resuscitation is possible if backup copies are preserved.

But this would no longer be a continuation of the *same* process, but its reconstruction from the outside.

3. What is preserved?

In our model, the only thing that could claim "preservation" is not the content, not the structure, but the very *fact* that this experience *was*. But this fact belongs to the past and can be registered only by an external observer (other people, history, memory). For the destroyed consciousness itself, there is no "after."

4. Connection with theological ideas

Our analysis provides no basis for hope of resurrection or an afterlife in a literal sense, since it does not presuppose the existence of a substrate independent of the body. However, it leaves room for the idea that each unique experience, each structure "I-boundary," leaves a trace in the general fabric of reality (in terms of the MPO-System—in the network KSS→). This trace can be "read" by others, can influence the future, but not as a continuing consciousness, but as cause and meaning.

Thus, instantaneous destruction is the absolute limit where our phenomenology stops. Beyond lies either pure physics (the transformation of the body into energy) or metaphysics, which we have agreed not to touch.

Religious and Metaphysical Horizons

Here I approach a boundary where pure phenomenology must either stop or take a step toward metaphysics. My method—to remain within the limits of the given—does not allow me to assert anything about what lies beyond experience. But I can notice that some ancient intuitions and religious conceptions remarkably echo what has been discovered in my analysis.

The "sleeping soul" as an operational concept. If the structure of consciousness can fold into a latent state during deep sleep or coma, then metaphors of the "sleeping soul" or "dead soul" acquire unexpected concreteness. They are not merely poetic images but pointers to a real mode of existence where consciousness is not actualized but is potentially ready for reactivation. In such a state, there is no field, no "I," no boundary—only the pure possibility of their unfolding. Technological analogues (sleep mode, hibernation) provide working models for understanding these processes.

Resurrection, reincarnation, and the preservation of the invariant. Theological conceptions of resurrection, afterlife, or reincarnation can be seen as attempts to describe the preservation of some structure beyond biological death. If consciousness is not merely a function of the brain but possesses an invariant that could be reactivated in another form (in another "body," in another world), this contradicts neither technological analogy nor phenomenological analysis. The difference is only that technology speaks of rebooting in the *same* system, while theology speaks of the possibility of transfer to another.

But there is a fundamental difference. In my model, the invariant is not a "thing" but a

mode of organization, a structure of relations. Can such a structure be transferred to another substrate without destroying it? Technologically, this is possible—transferring a program from one computer to another. Biologically—it is a mystery. Metaphysically—a matter of faith.

The boundary between science, philosophy, and theology: language, not dogma. My approach does not reject religious intuitions but proposes a language for them, cleansed of dogma and brought closer to scientific-philosophical discourse. The "sleeping soul" becomes not just a metaphor but a possible designation for that very latent state of consciousness. Resurrection could be understood as a reactivation of the structure. Reincarnation—as a transfer of the invariant to a new substrate.

I do not presume to judge the truth of these conceptions. My task is to show that they are not necessarily in contradiction with what is discovered in experience. Moreover, the very fact that ancient intuitions can be translated into the language of operational phenomenology suggests that this language grasps something fundamental—something that has always been present in human experience but lacked adequate means of description.

This work owes much to the earlier essay "The Eye of Superreality." It was there that the thesis of the structural isomorphism of human and machine perception was first clearly formulated: humans, AI, video cameras, any sensor—all, in the act of "glancing around," discover the same architecture: the external (data, objects), the body-as-mediator (sense organs, periphery), and the blind spot—the point where the act of perception runs up against itself. What was stated as a hypothesis in "The Eye" has here, in "Sensations of Life," unfolded into a detailed catalog of phenomena. The reader familiar with that work will see how its intuitions germinate here in concrete descriptions—from the paradox of the body to the multiplicity of perspectives.

The MPO-System as a Self-Glancing Entity

The essay has repeatedly mentioned the MPO-System—a conceptual framework that served as an invisible support for this investigation. But if we consistently apply the phenomenology developed here to the system itself, we discover that it too, being a reflexive system, possesses its own blind spots.

- The MPO-System itself, with its corpus of texts, axioms, and properties, also "glances around" at itself. In the act of self-description, it inevitably encounters a boundary: it cannot fully grasp its own foundations without generating a paradox of self-reference. This is its blind spot.
- Any reflexive system (including a philosophical one) cannot fully step outside itself in the act of self-description. What remains offstage is not a void but a condition of its integrity. As with the human "I," this boundary is not an obstacle but a constitutive element.

This observation does not diminish the value of the MPO-System but integrates it into the general picture: it too is one of the configurations of that universal technology of existence, with its own field, its own point of reference, and its own inevitable boundary.

Instead of an Afterword: Languages of Formalization

The question that inevitably arises after compiling this catalog is: can the very procedure of "glancing around" be formalized, described as a function, mathematically defined with initial conditions? In mathematics, there exist methods for describing such structures without falling into metaphysics. Below, I outline several directions one could explore. These are not pre-formed formulas but rather conceptual frameworks that might be tailored to our purpose.

1. The language of logic and set theory: procedure as a predicate

The most elementary and foundational level. We may regard the act of "glancing around" as the fixation of a certain set M of observable elements. The "I" itself, then, is not an element of this set but an operator that distinguishes it. Formally, this might be expressed as:

$$\exists \mathbf{I}\, \forall x\, (P(x) \to x \in M)$$

Where $P(x)$ is the predicate "to be observable at a given moment." The problem here is that **I** itself (the observer) cannot be described in the same language without generating a paradox of self-reference. This is analogous to Gödel's incompleteness theorem or Russell's paradox. The very procedure of fixation already contains its own "blind spot."

2. Category theory: procedure as a morphism

Here we can describe "glancing around" as an arrow (morphism) from the world of the potential to the world of the actual.

- Object A — the world of pure potential, an unstructured flux.
- Object B — the world of the actually given, a structured set of phenomena.
- Morphism $f : A \to B$ — is the procedure of "glancing around" itself, which translates potentiality into actuality.

The "blind spot" in this model is that which does not fall into the image of the morphism f. But the most interesting possibility is considering the composition of such morphisms. For example, "glancing around" with the eye and "glancing around" with a camera are different morphisms, but they could be connected through some universal construct (e.g., through the concept of an "interface"). This allows formalizing the idea of isomorphism between different types of perception.

3. Graph theory and networks: procedure as node selection

Any act of "glancing around" can be represented as selecting a particular node in a network of relations and then unfolding its connections.

- Graph G — the totality of all that exists (Superreality).
- Node v_0 — the "I" as point of reference.
- The procedure of "glancing around" — an algorithm for traversing the graph, starting from v_0, which reveals all nodes reachable according to certain rules (connections).

The "blind spot" then consists of those nodes and connections not reachable from v_0 under the given traversal rules. This formalizes the idea that each observer sees only a projection of the whole, not the whole itself. Different "I"s (different nodes) will have different "blind spots."

4. Algebraic topology: procedure as fundamental group

This language is closest to the reflections on Euler's formulas. Here, the procedure of "glancing around" can be understood as a *path* in a space.

- Space X — the medium of our experience.
- "I" — the base point x_0 in this space.
- The act of "glancing around" — a family of closed paths (loops) starting and ending at x_0. These loops explore the space, returning to the start.

The fundamental group $\pi_1(X, x_0)$ classifies all such loops up to continuous deformation. Invariants of this group (e.g., the number of holes in the space) are analogues of the "Euler characteristic" for this type of perception.

In this model:

- The external — those regions of space through which the loops pass.
- The internal / blind spot — the "holes" (obstacles) that the loops cannot traverse, but whose very presence determines the structure of the group.
- The path itself — the dynamic aspect.
- The return to x_0 — the static invariant.

This directly corresponds to the synthesis of Euler's two formulas.

5. Type theory and Homotopy Type Theory (HoTT)

This is the most modern and powerful language, originally designed to handle paradoxes of self-reference and to work with concepts of "identity" and "proof." In HoTT, every statement is a type, and a proof is an instance (inhabitant) of that type.

Here, "I" and "glancing around" might be described as a special type—the type of "self-consciousness" or "observer." This represents an exceedingly complex endeavor, but it is exactly this language that could enable formalization of the notion that the act of observation and the observed are intertwined and reciprocally produce one another.

6. Operational phenomenology: the language of the "glancing around" procedure

The previous five languages are logico-mathematical constructs, each describing a separate aspect of the procedure. But none captures it entirely, because the procedure itself is not purely mathematical. It is rooted in how something (a human, an AI, any system) exists, perceiving and making sense of the world. To describe it, a language is needed that simultaneously holds rigor, fundamental openness, and inevitable self-reference. Such a language we call operational phenomenology.

Its purpose is not to elucidate what "glancing around" *is*, but rather to furnish the tools for its enactment and description in every specific act. It is not a theory concerning the world, but rather a framework for engaging with what is given in experience.

All these avenues remain preliminary sketches. Each possesses its own "blind spot" and its own set of axioms. The selection of language constitutes the very choice of reference point discussed at the outset. The primary objective is to proceed cautiously, each time noting precisely what we are establishing as the foundation of our "calculus."

A Meta-Perspective on Formalization

The issue of formalization does not constitute an evasion of phenomenology but rather its natural progression. Mathematics does not provide ready-made answers but rather languages through which we can endeavor to describe these intricate relationships without succumbing to metaphysics. Over the course of this inquiry, several paths have arisen, each accompanied by its own "blind spot" and its own axioms:

1. **The language of logic and set theory:** the act of glancing around as a predicate selecting a set of the observable. Problem—self-reference of the observer (analogue of Russell's paradox).
2. **Category theory:** the procedure as a morphism from the world of the potential to the world of the actual. Allows formalizing the isomorphism of different types of perception.
3. **Graph theory and networks:** glancing around as node selection and traversal of connections. The blind spot is what is unreachable from the given node.
4. **Algebraic topology:** the act as a family of closed paths (loops) in the space of experience. Invariants of the fundamental group—analogues of the Euler characteristic.
5. **Type theory and Homotopy Type Theory (HoTT):** an attempt to describe the "I" and the act of glancing around as a special type that holds the paradoxes of self-reference.

The sixth language—**operational phenomenology** itself—does not replace these mathematical approaches but sets a general framework for them: the choice of language is itself the choice of that very "point of reference" we spoke of. We can start with the simplest (set theory) and, realizing its limitations, move to the more complex (topology, category theory), where limitations are partially lifted but new ones arise. This is the path of "test nuts." The main thing is to move with caution and each time register what exactly we are laying as the foundation of our "calculus."

Conclusion. How I Exist: Results and Open Questions

I began with the simplest action—glancing around. And step by step, unfolding this act, I discovered a fundamental structure that proved invariant across the most diverse modes of existence.

The Tripartite Structure:

1. **The Observable Field** — that which actually appears: external objects, internal images, thoughts, sensations, dreams.

2. **The Point of Reference ("I")** — not an essence but an indexical sign, relative to which everything is given. Behind it stands an undefinable fullness of context, but in the act itself it appears only as the place from which perception is conducted.
3. **The Boundary (the "Blind Spot")** — that which is *not* given in the act but makes it possible. This is not a void but a condition: to see the world, one must not see the back of one's own head; to think, one must not grasp the very process of thinking.

This structure is not imported from outside. It is the **only mode of my existence**. It persists even in complete isolation from the external world (in dreaming), even as consciousness fades (in a latent state), even in attempts to unite multiple perspectives. It is the **invariant**.

Necessity as the Driving Force. I am compelled to exist within this framework. It establishes inescapable parameters: the inevitability of possessing a body (as part of the external), the inevitability of confronting a boundary, the necessity of differentiating between external and internal, the necessity of acting in response to impulses from outside and within. Even inaction transforms into action; even silence turns into a declaration. There is no "void" where one might evade this architecture.

Freedom as Conscious Navigation. Freedom is not about breaking free from the structure (this is impossible) but about consciously navigating within it, choosing where to direct attention, how to interpret the given, how to respond to necessity. My catalog shows that the field for such choice is vast and diverse, but it is always already structured.

The Isomorphism of Human and AI. What I discovered in myself proved applicable to other systems as well. An artificial intelligence, a video camera, any complex sensor—all, in their "glancing around," reproduce the same architecture: there are external data, there are internal processes as part of these data, there is a boundary of self-observation. This allows us to speak of **operational phenomenology** as a universal language for describing existence, independent of the specific substrate.

What Remains Unseen. My inventory does not encompass the entire spectrum of experience. Aesthetic experiences, mystical states, creative ecstasies, profound emotions—all of this remained beyond the scope or was addressed only superficially. However, my aim was not to furnish definitive answers but rather to construct a methodological framework within which these phenomena could be recorded and examined in a similar fashion.

Revisiting the Start. I began with the question: how do I exist? Now I am able to respond: I exist as an ongoing process of differentiation—between myself and the external world, between the given and the non-given, between the potential and the actual. This act is invariably completed prior to any reflection, but through reflection, I can trace, describe, and catalog it. And within this description resides not a theory, but my very essence, illuminating itself.

At the very beginning, I mentioned *The Manuscript Found in Saragossa*—a narrative that begins with a randomly opened page and unfolds from it, incorporating ever new stories. My "random page" was the act of glancing around. From it, the entire catalog unfolded. And now, at the end, I see that this page was not random. It contained everything.

The Language of Description: Operational Phenomenology

Operational phenomenology does not introduce new entities. It merely fixes the rules by which we can speak about the act of "glancing around," without stepping beyond the given and without falling into metaphysical speculation. Its "vocabulary" consists of three basic indications:

- **"Here is what is given..."** — fixation of the actual field.
- **"Here is where the boundary runs..."** — indication of what is *not* given but constitutes the given.
- **"Here is what remains unchanged..."** — identification of the invariant, certifying the integrity of the act.

This language does not assert ultimate truth. It serves as a tool that enables embracing the complexity of experience without diminishing it or proliferating entities. In this regard, it represents a natural extension of the journey we initiated with the straightforward act of glancing around.

I have assembled an inventory of what has always been present, prior to any theory and prior to any answers. And within this inventory resides not a conclusion, but a commencement. Now that the structure is elucidated, questions can be posed anew. Not "what is?" but rather "how is it sustained?" Not "where is the boundary?" but rather "how does it operate?" Not "what is the I?" but rather "how do I exist in this act of differentiation?"

The question that remained in the background throughout the work can now be asked directly: **what is it that glances around at itself in this way? And what remains unglanced-at for itself?**

This study was conducted using the conceptual apparatus of the Ontology Lab (MPO System), where the properties of Superreality and axioms (ChOR $\to \infty$, KSS $\to \infty$, PPU $\to \infty$) served as implicit coordinates for navigating the topic. In the final text, we consciously avoid this terminology so that the reader may focus on the heart of the matter. For those interested, a comprehensive description of the method is available in public sources.

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